



A WorkSmart-AI Guide for Higher Education

From Chatbot to Workflow

One task. Four levels of AI use.

What more could you and your team be achieving with AI?

This HE staff-facing guide shows you the art of the possible when it comes to using AI within the university workplace; how one task can evolve from being a basic chatbot prompt to an automated workflow that runs without them.

Level 1

Conversational

Level 2

Structured

Level 3

Configured

Level 4

Agentic

Most AI training stops at Level 1.

Did you know that currently the majority of higher education staff who use AI are only scratching the surface of its potential!

Most staff new to AI might open a chatbot, type a question and read the answer – at WorkSmart-AI we call this level 1 (out of 6!).

But we know that with structured and personalised training, people's AI capabilities can improve dramatically – making them more confident, productive and innovative in their roles.

That's why we've produced this guide - to help you and your team work out what level you're currently working at and where you could strive to get to (and the time saved).

Using our specifically designed WorkSmart-AI Use Hierarchy, we focus on one task (familiar to everyone) to demonstrate how much more you can get from AI in the workplace.

“Moving from Level 1 to Level 2 alone can save 2-3 hours per staff member per week across common tasks. Most HE institutions are leaving that time on the table.”

The WorkSmart-AI Use Hierarchy

Six levels of AI use, each building on the last. Most HE staff currently sit at Level 1.

1	Conversational AI Single-turn chatbot use. Paste, read, review manually.	All staff
2	Structured Prompting R-C-T frameworks. AI embedded in M365 tools such as Copilot in Teams.	All staff
3	Custom Configuration Custom GPTs, Copilot agents, persistent instructions. Configured once.	All staff
4	Agentic Workflows Multi-step automated tasks via Power Automate. Minimal human input.	All staff (adv.)
5	Specialist AI Tools Purpose-built AI for specific roles - research, legal, finance.	Role-specific
6	Integration & Orch. API connections and multi-agent pipelines. IT and digital leads.	IT / Digital

This guide follows one task through Levels 1-4. Levels 5-6 are referenced as the horizon.

1

Conversational AI

Where most HE staff are right now.

THE TASK: Meeting notes → clean action summary for circulation.

What this looks like

- A staff member opens ChatGPT, Copilot chat, or a similar chatbot.
- They copy-paste rough notes and add a one-line request.
- They read the output, edit manually, and send it on.
- Next time, the same ad hoc process starts again from scratch.

EXAMPLE PROMPT

Here are my rough notes from today's meeting. Please tidy them up and pull out the key action points.

Format as:

- (1) Short summary
- (2) Decisions made
- (3) Actions - owner and deadline for each

[paste your notes here]

15-20 mins

estimated time saved

OUTPUT QUALITY

Variable. Better than nothing, but inconsistent across staff and occasions.

Tools: ChatGPT (free), Microsoft Copilot chat (free tier), Google Gemini

2

Structured Prompting

Same task. A repeatable system.

THE TASK: Meeting notes → clean action summary for circulation.

What this looks like

- Staff apply the R-C-T framework - Role, Context, Task - every time.
- They use Copilot inside Teams or Word, where the meeting happened.
- They maintain a saved prompt template for recurring meeting types.
- Output is consistent, shareable, and requires only light review.

EXAMPLE PROMPT

Role: You are an experienced PA at a UK university.

Context: I have just finished a 45-minute project steering meeting. Attendees: HoD, Project Manager, Finance Lead, IT Lead.

Task: Produce a meeting summary with:

(1) Decisions made

(2) Action items - owner role and deadline for each

(3) Items to carry forward

Use formal, concise language suitable for circulation.

[paste your notes here]

25-35 mins

estimated time saved

OUTPUT QUALITY

Consistent and shareable. Can be circulated after light review rather than a full redraft.

Tools: Microsoft Copilot in Teams or Word (M365 licence), ChatGPT with saved prompt library

3

Custom Configuration

Configured once. Works every time.

THE TASK: Meeting notes → clean action summary for circulation.

What this looks like

- A Custom GPT or Copilot agent is built once with the institutional template loaded.
- It knows your headings, terminology, and governance language.
- Staff paste notes in - no configuration needed each time.
- Different agents can cover different meeting types.

SYSTEM CONFIGURATION (set once, shared with all staff)

Institutional meeting note template loaded as system instructions

Required headings: Attendees | Summary | Decisions | Actions | Carry Forward

Preferred terminology and governance or compliance language pre-loaded

Staff input: paste notes only - no prompting skills required

Separate agents available for: Steering | Welfare checks | Committee papers

35-45 mins

estimated time saved

OUTPUT QUALITY

Near-zero formatting work. Output matches your institutional template automatically. One build serves the whole team.

Tools: ChatGPT Plus (Custom GPTs), Microsoft Copilot Studio (M365 licence)

4

Agentic Workflows

The task runs itself.

THE TASK: Meeting notes → clean action summary for circulation.

What this looks like

- Teams transcribes the meeting automatically as it happens.
- Power Automate detects the completed transcript and triggers the workflow.
- The structured summary is saved to SharePoint automatically.
- Action owners receive email notifications. Zero post-meeting admin.

AUTOMATED FLOW (no manual steps required)

Teams records and transcribes the meeting in real time

Power Automate detects new transcript and triggers the workflow

Copilot generates structured summary using institutional template

Summary saved to SharePoint + action owners emailed automatically

50-60 mins

estimated time saved

OUTPUT QUALITY

The task removes itself from the to-do list. Available today in M365. This is not a future capability.

Tools: Microsoft Teams transcription, Power Automate, Copilot (M365 Copilot licence required)

Now imagine this applied to...

Every task follows the same four-level arc - from chatbot prompt to automated workflow. Where do your staff currently sit on each one?

Student Enquiry Responses

Registry staff handling high-volume routine queries consistently and at speed.

Assessment Feedback Drafts

Academic staff generating structured, criteria-referenced feedback at scale.

Onboarding New Staff

HR producing personalised induction packs tailored to each new starter's role.

Research Grant Applications

Researchers drafting background sections and methodology outlines from notes.

Processing Committee Papers

Governance teams summarising board packs with decisions and actions extracted.

Drafting Job Adverts

HR creating role-specific job descriptions from bullet-point briefs.

Module Handbook Updates

Programme leaders refreshing course docs and ILOs each academic year.

Student Welfare Comms

Personal tutors generating welfare outreach messages for at-risk students.

These are 8 of the 290+ use cases in the WorkSmart-AI HE Use Case Bank. Every one follows the same progression.

Take your staff from Level 1 to Level 4.

WorkSmart-AI is a UK-based AI training and consultancy business built specifically for higher education. We design and deliver structured AI literacy programmes that take staff through the full hierarchy - not just the first step.

Workshop Programme

F2F and online workshops covering all staff roles and hierarchy levels. From foundations through to agentic workflows.

All staff

HE Use Case Bank

290+ use cases mapped to 14 staff roles. Green/Amber/Red risk ratings. Ready-to-use prompt starters.

Included in all programmes

Leadership Clarity

Strategic 1:1 advisory for senior leaders. Designed for strategic decision-makers including PS directors and heads of faculty/ department.

Senior leadership

Start with a free 45-minute conversation.

Book a call: worksmart-ai.co.uk

Email us: hello@worksmart-ai.co.uk

LinkedIn: linkedin.com/company/worksmart-ai



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